

GOOD Intent BAD Delivery

The first year of UPA II is a saga of missed opportunities. Manmohan Singh is now the longest serving prime minister in 25 years. Voters expect the man who freed the economy to now liberate India from bureaucratic sloth and get his team to perform.

By Shankkar Aiyar

Six days, they say, is a long time in politics; six years is almost an era. As UPA II enters the second year in power, Manmohan Singh will enter his seventh in office—the longest serving prime minister in 25 years. For a person often described as non-political, someone not born into the Nehru-Gandhi dynasty, the achievement is singular. Brutus within the Congress and Shakunis outside have tried their best to target him. Such is his aura that those who attacked him have been decimated, whether it was veteran Congressman Arjun Singh during UPA I or BJP's L.K. Advani or even the Left. The unassailability comes from public faith in his sincerity as also that of the Gandhi family. It is not known if any celebrations are planned at Race Course

Road, but his aides believe it is highly unlikely. You could put this down to his shy, unassuming, almost reclusive persona. You could also argue that the erudite mind realises that his legacy can't just be about tenure.

Sadly, the first 12 months of UPA II can only be defined as a saga of good intentions ruined by poor implementation. The most charitable description of the Government is that it is in a drift. This is best reflected in the fact that over half the ministers rated have scored less than 40 per cent marks. The list of missed opportunities far outweighs achievements like the passing of the Right to Education Act. The window of opportunity for big bang reforms opened by the exit of the Left has been squandered. Much promised pension, insurance, power and banking reforms are mired in a legislative quagmire. Infrastructure is both a driver of

growth and employment but the track record of the Government, whether on the promise of 20 km of roads per day or crucial irrigation projects, is tardy at best. On the social sector, the Government spend has crossed over Rs 1,00,000 crore just on poverty alleviation but there is no mechanism yet that ensures outlays translate into measurable outcomes. The Food Security Bill touted as a major idea has now been debated for over nine months. Despite being voted back to power with an improved count of 207 MPs, the alliance is a flailing regime lurching from one issue to another, from one session to another. Keynesian politics defined by the sharing of pelf clearly has its limits as political sustainability is not guaranteed.

Yes, under Manmohan's watch, India has grown into a trillion-dollar economy; its foreign exchange reserves are up from \$113 billion in